变脸

一张面具，一份信任

The Face-Changer's Apprentice

One Mask, One Trust

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 5 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 成都[1]人爱喝茶，也爱看戏。在城市西边的一条老街上，有一家开了五十多年的茶馆[2]，叫“清风[3]茶馆”。每个星期六晚上，茶馆里都有川剧[4]表演。客人们一边喝着盖碗茶[5]，一边看台上的演员唱戏。最受欢迎的节目，是最后的变脸[6]。

茶馆里的表演

2 明浩[7]第一次看变脸，是十三岁那年的春天。那天是爷爷的生日，全家人一起去了清风茶馆。锣鼓[8]一响，一个穿着红衣服、戴着高帽子的演员走上了舞台。他手里拿着一把扇子，脸是红色的，眼睛又大又亮。

3 演员在台上走了几步，突然把头一甩[9]，扇子在脸前一挡，红脸就变成了绿脸。

1 成都 *Chéngdū* Chengdu, capital of Sichuan
2 茶馆 *cháguǎn* teahouse
3 清风 *Qīngfēng* Qingfeng (“Clear Breeze”)
4 川剧 *Chuānjù* Sichuan opera
5 盖碗茶 *gàiwǎnchá* tea in a lidded bowl
6 变脸 *biànliǎn* face-changing (Sichuan opera art)
7 明浩 *Míng Hào* Ming Hao (the boy)
8 锣鼓 *luógǔ* gongs and drums
9 甩 *shuǎi* to flick, to swing

The people of Chengdu love drinking tea, and they love going to the opera. 1
On an old street in the west of the city there is a teahouse that has been open for more than fifty years, called the Qingfeng Teahouse. Every Saturday evening there is a Sichuan opera show in the teahouse. The customers sip tea from lidded bowls while they watch the actors sing on the stage. The most popular act is the last one: face-changing.

The Show in the Teahouse

Ming Hao first saw face-changing in the spring of the year he turned thir- 2
teen. It was his grandfather's birthday, and the whole family went to the Qingfeng Teahouse together. As soon as the gongs and drums sounded, an actor in red clothes and a tall hat walked onto the stage. He held a fan in his hand; his face was red, and his eyes were big and bright.

The actor took a few steps across the stage, then suddenly flicked his head, 3
swept the fan in front of his face, and the red face turned into a green one.

观众还没反应过来，绿脸又变成了黑脸，然后是白脸、金脸……一张接一张，快得连眼睛都看不清楚。明浩[1]站了起来，嘴张得大大的，手里的糖掉了一地。

最后，演员把扇子一收，露出[2]了自己本来的脸——一张老人的脸，头发已经白了，可是眼睛还是很亮。台下的掌声[3]响了很久。爷爷告诉明浩："这是唐师傅[4]，在这家茶馆[5]演了三十多年了。成都[6]喜欢川剧[7]的人，没有不知道他的。"

回家的路上，明浩一句话也没说。到了晚上，他躺在床上，一闭[8]上眼睛，就看见那些颜色不同的脸。那些脸是怎么变的？为什么那么快？他越想越睡不着。第二天早上，他对妈妈说："我想学变脸[9]。我非学会不可！"

1 明浩 *Míng Hào* Ming Hao (the boy)
2 露出 *lùchū* to reveal
3 掌声 *zhǎngshēng* applause
4 唐师傅 *Táng shīfu* Master Tang
5 茶馆 *cháguǎn* teahouse
6 成都 *Chéngdū* Chengdu, capital of Sichuan
7 川剧 *Chuānjù* Sichuan opera
8 闭 *bì* to close
9 变脸 *biànliǎn* face-changing (Sichuan opera art)

Before the audience could react, the green face became a black one, then a white one, then a gold one... one after another, so fast that the eye could not even follow them. Ming Hao stood up with his mouth wide open, and the sweets in his hand fell all over the floor. 3

Finally the actor closed his fan and revealed his own face: an old man's face, his hair already white, but his eyes still bright. The applause below the stage went on for a long time. Grandpa told Ming Hao, "That's Master Tang. He has performed in this teahouse for more than thirty years. There isn't a Sichuan opera fan in Chengdu who doesn't know him." 4

On the way home, Ming Hao did not say a word. That night, lying in bed, the moment he closed his eyes he saw all those faces of different colours. How did those faces change? Why so fast? The more he thought about it, the less he could sleep. The next morning he told his mother, "I want to learn face-changing. I simply have to learn it!" 5

妈妈笑了：“你呀，又是三分钟热度[1]。”

不收徒弟[2]

第二个星期六，明浩[3]一个人来到了茶馆[4]。演出结束以后，他在后台[5]门口等了半个小时，终于等到了唐师傅[6]。他跑过去，大声说：“唐师傅，我想跟您学变脸[7]！”唐师傅看了他一眼，一边收拾箱子，一边说：“我不收徒弟。”“为什么？我可以每天来，我不怕累！”“这句话，谁都会说。光凭一句话，我不能相信你。你再说一百遍也没用。回家写作业去吧。”

明浩没有放弃。从那天起，他每天放学以后都去茶馆。他帮倒茶的王叔叔[8]洗茶碗，帮老板搬椅子，演出的时候就站在最后面看。

1 三分钟热度 *sān fēnzhōng rèdù* short-lived enthusiasm
2 徒弟 *túdì* apprentice, disciple
3 明浩 *Míng Hào* Ming Hao (the boy)
4 茶馆 *cháguǎn* teahouse
5 后台 *hòutái* backstage
6 唐师傅 *Táng shīfu* Master Tang
7 变脸 *biànliǎn* face-changing (Sichuan opera art)
8 王叔叔 *Wáng shūshu* Uncle Wang

His mother laughed. "Oh you. Another three-minute craze." 5

"I Take No Apprentices"

The next Saturday, Ming Hao went to the teahouse by himself. After the 6
show he waited by the backstage door for half an hour, and at last Master Tang came out. He ran over and said loudly, "Master Tang, I want to learn face-changing from you!" Master Tang glanced at him and, packing up his trunk, said, "I don't take apprentices." "Why not? I can come every day. I'm not afraid of hard work!" "Anyone can say that. I can't take you at your word alone. You can say it a hundred times and it won't help. Go home and do your homework."

Ming Hao did not give up. From that day on, he went to the teahouse every 7
day after school. He helped Uncle Wang, who poured the tea, wash the tea bowls, helped the owner carry chairs, and during the shows he stood at the very back and watched.

7 时间长了，连茶馆[1]里的老客人都认识他了，开玩笑地叫他“小唐[2]”。可是唐师傅[3]好像没看见他一样，一句话也不跟他说。

8 有一天，王叔叔[4]一边用长嘴壶[5]倒茶，一边小声告诉他：“你别怪唐师傅。他以前收过一个徒弟[6]，教了他五年。后来那个人为了钱，把师傅教的东西随便告诉别人，还拍成视频卖。唐师傅很伤心，从那以后，就再也不收徒弟了。”“可是我不会那样做的。”明浩[7]说。王叔叔摇了摇头：“那个人当年也是这么说的。”

9 那天晚上下起了大雨。茶馆关门的时候，明浩还在门口帮忙收桌子。唐师傅打着伞走出来，在他面前停住了。“你真的想学？”“真的！”“学变脸[8]很苦。一旦开始，就不能随便放弃。”“我不放弃！”

1 茶馆 *cháguǎn* teahouse
2 唐 *Táng* Tang (surname)
3 唐师傅 *Táng shīfu* Master Tang
4 王叔叔 *Wáng shūshu* Uncle Wang
5 长嘴壶 *chángzuǐhú* long-spouted teapot
6 徒弟 *túdì* apprentice, disciple
7 明浩 *Míng Hào* Ming Hao (the boy)
8 变脸 *biànliǎn* face-changing (Sichuan opera art)

As time went by, even the regulars at the teahouse knew him and jokingly called him "Little Tang". But Master Tang acted as if he did not see him, and never said a word to him. 7

One day, as he poured tea from his long-spouted pot, Uncle Wang told him quietly, "Don't blame Master Tang. He once took an apprentice and taught him for five years. Later, for money, that young man told anyone who asked what his master had taught him, and even made videos of it to sell. Master Tang was heartbroken, and since then he has never taken another apprentice." "But I would never do that," said Ming Hao. Uncle Wang shook his head. "That's exactly what that young man said back then." 8

That evening it began to pour. When the teahouse closed, Ming Hao was still at the door helping to clear the tables. Master Tang came out under an umbrella and stopped in front of him. "You really want to learn?" "I really do!" "Learning face-changing is hard. Once you start, you can't just give up." "I won't give up!" 9

唐师傅[1]看着他湿了的头发，过了很久才说：“好吧。不过我先说清楚：我不是收你当徒弟[2]，只是让你试试。明天早上六点，到河边的公园来找我。”

一年的基本功[3]

第二天早上，天还没完全亮，明浩[4]就到了公园。唐师傅已经在那儿了。明浩很兴奋：“师傅，今天就开始学变脸[5]吗？”“变脸？”唐师傅笑了一下，“你连马步[6]都站不稳，还想变脸？要学变脸，非先把基本功练好不可。一年以内，不许碰面具[7]。”“一年？！”“觉得长，现在就可以回家。”

1 唐师傅 *Táng shīfu* Master Tang
2 徒弟 *túdì* apprentice, disciple
3 基本功 *jīběngōng* basic training, fundamentals
4 明浩 *Míng Hào* Ming Hao (the boy)
5 变脸 *biànliǎn* face-changing (Sichuan opera art)
6 马步 *mǎbù* horse stance
7 面具 *miànjù* mask

Master Tang looked at his wet hair for a long time before he said, "All right. 9
But let me be clear: I'm not taking you as my apprentice. I'm only letting you try. Be at the riverside park at six tomorrow morning."

A Year of Basics

The next morning, before it was fully light, Ming Hao arrived at the park. 10
Master Tang was already there. Ming Hao was very excited. "Master, do we start learning face-changing today?" "Face-changing?" Master Tang gave a little laugh. "You can't even hold a horse stance steady, and you want to change faces? If you want to learn face-changing, you must get the basics right first. For one year, you are not allowed to touch a mask." "A year?!" "If that's too long, you can go home right now."

11 明浩[1]没有回家。从那天开始，他每天早上六点到公园跟唐师傅[2]练功[3]。站马步[4]、走台步[5]、练眼神[6]、转头、甩手[7]……每一个动作都要做几百遍。唐师傅还点一支香，在他眼前慢慢地移动，让他的眼睛跟着香头转，不许眨眼[8]。练了一个星期，明浩的腿疼得上楼都很困难，晚上累得连饭都不想吃。

12 最难的是练手。唐师傅给了他一块小小的红布，让他放在袖子[9]里，然后在一秒钟以内拿出来，再放回去，不能让人看见。“变脸[10]的时候，观众的眼睛都看着你的脸和手。你的手再快，观众要是看出来了，也没有用。”明浩每天对着镜子练两个小时。尽管手指常常酸得发抖[11]，他还是不肯[12]停下来。

1 明浩 *Míng Hào* Ming Hao (the boy)
2 唐师傅 *Táng shīfu* Master Tang
3 练功 *liàngōng* to train (in a martial or stage art)
4 马步 *mǎbù* horse stance
5 台步 *táibù* stage walk
6 眼神 *yǎnshén* expression of the eyes
7 甩 *shuǎi* to flick, to swing
8 眨眼 *zhǎyǎn* to blink
9 袖子 *xiùzi* sleeve
10 变脸 *biànliǎn* face-changing (Sichuan opera art)
11 发抖 *fādǒu* to tremble
12 肯 *kěn* willing to

Ming Hao did not go home. From that day on, he came to the park at six 11
every morning to train with Master Tang. Horse stance, stage walking, eye expression, turning the head, flicking the hands... every movement had to be done hundreds of times. Master Tang would also light a stick of incense and move it slowly in front of his eyes, and make his eyes follow the glowing tip without blinking. After a week of this, Ming Hao's legs hurt so much that even climbing the stairs was hard, and in the evenings he was too tired even to eat.

The hardest part was training his hands. Master Tang gave him a little piece 12
of red cloth to keep in his sleeve; he had to take it out and put it back within a second, without anyone seeing. "When you change faces, every eye in the audience is on your face and your hands. However fast your hands are, if the audience can see what you're doing, it's no use." Ming Hao practised in front of the mirror for two hours a day. Even though his fingers often ached until they trembled, he refused to stop.

13 夏天过去了，秋天也过去了。冬天的早上，公园里又冷又黑，明浩[†]不得不五点多就起床。周末同学们约他出去玩，他也不去。有时候他也会想："师傅是不是只想让我知难而退[‡]？"可是每次想放弃的时候，他就会想起茶馆[§]里那一张接一张的脸。再累，他也要把每天的功[¶]练完。

14 唐师傅[*]话很少，几乎从来不表扬他。可是有一天练完功，师傅看着他的手，说了三个字："稳多了。"那天，明浩高兴得一路跑回了家。妈妈看到他每天这么早出门，再也不说他是"三分钟热度[#]"了。

† 明浩 *Míng Hào* Ming Hao (the boy)
‡ 知难而退 *zhīnán ér tuì* to back off when it gets hard
§ 茶馆 *cháguǎn* teahouse
¶ 功 *gōng* training, exercises
* 唐师傅 *Táng shīfu* Master Tang
\# 三分钟热度 *sān fēnzhōng rèdù* short-lived enthusiasm

Summer passed, and so did autumn. On winter mornings the park was cold and dark, and Ming Hao had to get up a little after five. When his classmates asked him out at the weekend, he would not go. Sometimes he wondered, "Does Master just want me to give up once I see how hard it is?" But every time he wanted to quit, he thought of those faces in the teahouse, one after another. However tired he was, he always finished each day's training. 13

Master Tang was a man of few words and almost never praised him. But one day, after training, Master looked at his hands and said three words: "Much steadier now." That day Ming Hao was so happy that he ran all the way home. Seeing him leave the house so early every day, his mother stopped calling it a "three-minute craze". 14

秘密

15 冬天到了，明浩[1]已经练了快十个月。他也越来越好奇：变脸[2]的秘密到底是什么？他问过师傅好几次，师傅总是说："时候还没到。"他在网上查过很多资料。有的说是把颜色抹[3]在脸上，有的说是一层一层的面具[4]，还有的说得非常神秘。网上也有一些视频，可是拍得很模糊，什么也看不清楚。他觉得这个问题非弄明白不可。

16 一天下午，明浩正在茶馆[5]帮忙，一个戴眼镜的年轻男人走过来，坐在他旁边。"小朋友，你是唐师傅[6]的徒弟[7]吧？""还不算。"男人笑了笑，小声说："我是拍短视频的。你帮我一个忙：下次演出的时候，用手机在后台[8]拍一下唐师傅准备的过程，特别是他的箱子里有什么。我给你两千块钱。"

1 明浩 *Míng Hào* Ming Hao (the boy)
2 变脸 *biànliǎn* face-changing (Sichuan opera art)
3 抹 *mǒ* to smear
4 面具 *miànjù* mask
5 茶馆 *cháguǎn* teahouse
6 唐师傅 *Táng shīfu* Master Tang
7 徒弟 *túdì* apprentice, disciple
8 后台 *hòutái* backstage

The Secret

Winter came, and Ming Hao had been training for almost ten months. He 15
grew more and more curious: what exactly was the secret of face-changing? He had asked Master several times, and Master always said, "It isn't time yet." He had looked up a lot online. Some said colour was smeared onto the face, some said it was layer upon layer of masks, and some made it sound very mysterious. There were videos online too, but they were blurry and you couldn't make anything out. He felt he simply had to get to the bottom of it.

One afternoon, while Ming Hao was helping out in the teahouse, a young 16
man in glasses came over and sat down next to him. "Hey kid, you're Master Tang's apprentice, right?" "Not yet." The man smiled and said quietly, "I make short videos. Do me a favour: at the next show, use your phone to film Master Tang getting ready backstage, especially what's in his trunk. I'll give you two thousand yuan."

16 明浩[†]很吃惊。两千块钱！他从来没有过那么多钱。

17 男人又说：“你想想，你跟他练了快一年，他连面具[‡]都不让你碰。说不定他根本就不想教你。拍几段视频，你自己在家就能学，还有钱拿，多好啊。”明浩低着头，没说话。男人说的这些，他自己也偷偷想过。

18 过了一会儿，明浩抬起头，说：“我不拍。”“三千？”“您给我再多的钱，我也不拍。”明浩站了起来，“师傅说过，变脸[§]的方法是他的师傅一代一代传下来的。他现在不教我，一定有他的道理。我想学，就要等他愿意教我的那一天。”男人摇了摇头，走了。明浩不知道，这时候唐师傅[¶]就站在楼梯后面，把他们的话都听见了。

† 明浩 *Míng Hào* Ming Hao (the boy)

‡ 面具 *miànjù* mask

§ 变脸 *biànliǎn* face-changing (Sichuan opera art)

¶ 唐师傅 *Táng shīfu* Master Tang

Ming Hao was startled. Two thousand yuan! He had never had that much money. 16

The man went on, "Think about it. You've trained with him for almost a year, and he won't even let you touch a mask. Maybe he never meant to teach you at all. Film a few clips and you can learn it yourself at home, and get paid as well. What could be better?" Ming Hao lowered his head and said nothing. He had secretly thought the very same things himself. 17

After a while Ming Hao raised his head and said, "I won't film it." "Three thousand?" "However much money you give me, I won't do it." Ming Hao stood up. "Master told me the method came down to him from his own master, generation after generation. If he isn't teaching me yet, he must have his reasons. If I want to learn, I have to wait for the day he's willing to teach me." The man shook his head and left. What Ming Hao did not know was that Master Tang was standing just behind the stairs at that moment and had heard every word. 18

19 那天晚上，唐师傅[1]什么也没说。可是第二天早上练完功[2]，他从包里拿出一个旧木盒子。打开盒子，里面是几张薄薄的面具[3]，颜色非常鲜艳。“今天开始，教你用面具。”明浩[4]的心跳得很快：“可是师傅，一年还没到……”“我知道。”唐师傅没有多解释。

20 接下来的一个月，唐师傅教他怎么准备面具，怎么在扇子挡住脸的那一刻把它拉下来。具体的方法，师傅让他答应不告诉任何人。明浩这才明白：变脸[5]的方法说起来并不复杂，难的是手。台上那么快的一下，没有一个动作不是练了几千遍的。没有那一年的基本功[6]，就算[7]知道了秘密，也变不出一张脸来。

1 唐师傅 *Táng shīfu* Master Tang
2 功 *gōng* training, exercises
3 面具 *miànjù* mask
4 明浩 *Míng Hào* Ming Hao (the boy)
5 变脸 *biànliǎn* face-changing (Sichuan opera art)
6 基本功 *jīběngōng* basic training, fundamentals
7 就算 *jiùsuàn* even if

That evening Master Tang said nothing. But the next morning, after training, he took an old wooden box out of his bag. Inside were several thin masks in very bright colours. "Starting today, I'll teach you to use the masks." Ming Hao's heart was racing. "But Master, the year isn't up yet..." "I know." Master Tang explained no further. 19

Over the next month, Master Tang taught him how to prepare the masks and how to pull one down in the instant the fan hid his face. As for the exact method, Master made him promise to tell no one. Only then did Ming Hao understand: the method of face-changing was not complicated to describe; the hard part was the hands. For that one quick flash on stage, there was not a single movement that had not been practised thousands of times. Without that year of basics, even someone who knew the secret could not have changed a single face. 20

意外

21 又过了一个月，春节快到了。一个星期六晚上，茶馆[1]里坐满了客人，还有不少外地来的游客。演出快开始的时候，后台[2]突然传来“砰[3]”的一声。明浩[4]跑进去一看，唐师傅[5]坐在地上，右手抱着左手，脸色发白。原来地上有水，他滑了一下，手腕[6]撞在了桌子角上。

22 老板也跑了进来，急得满头大汗[7]：“唐师傅，您的手怎么样？”唐师傅试着动了动手指，疼得直吸气。“今天变不了了。”“那怎么办？今天的客人很多都是专门来看变脸[8]的，票都卖出去了。这场戏非演不可啊！”

23 后台一下子安静了下来。过了一会儿，唐师傅抬起头，看着明浩。“你上。”

1 茶馆 *cháguǎn* teahouse
2 后台 *hòutái* backstage
3 砰 *pēng* bang! thud!
4 明浩 *Míng Hào* Ming Hao (the boy)
5 唐师傅 *Táng shīfu* Master Tang
6 手腕 *shǒuwàn* wrist
7 满头大汗 *mǎntóu dàhàn* sweating all over
8 变脸 *biànliǎn* face-changing (Sichuan opera art)

The Accident

Another month went by, and the Spring Festival was near. One Saturday 21
evening the teahouse was full of customers, including quite a few tourists from out of town. Just before the show was due to start, there was a sudden thud from backstage. Ming Hao ran in and saw Master Tang sitting on the floor, holding his left hand in his right, his face pale. There had been water on the floor; he had slipped and struck his wrist on the corner of a table.

The owner ran in too, sweating with worry. "Master Tang, how's your 22
hand?" Master Tang tried to move his fingers and sucked in his breath with pain. "I can't change faces tonight." "Then what do we do? Lots of tonight's customers came specially to see the face-changing, and the tickets are all sold. This show has to go on!"

Backstage went suddenly quiet. After a moment, Master Tang looked up at 23
Ming Hao. "You go on."

23 明浩[1]吓了一跳：“我？师傅，我才学了一个月的面具[2]，我……”“你练了一年的手。”唐师傅[3]的声音很平静，“今天只变两次：红脸变黑脸，黑脸变金脸。记住，台上不管出了什么事，再紧张也不能停下来。”

24 唐师傅用一只手帮他准备，嘴里不停地说着要注意的地方。明浩穿上了师傅的戏服[4]，衣服太大了，老板找来几个夹子帮他夹好。虽然手一直在发抖[5]，他还是努力记住师傅说的每一句话。锣鼓[6]响了。明浩深深[7]地吸了一口气，走上了舞台。

1 明浩 *Míng Hào* Ming Hao (the boy)
2 面具 *miànjù* mask
3 唐师傅 *Táng shīfu* Master Tang
4 戏服 *xìfú* stage costume
5 发抖 *fādǒu* to tremble
6 锣鼓 *luógǔ* gongs and drums
7 深深 *shēnshēn* deeply

Ming Hao jumped. "Me? Master, I've only been learning the masks for a month, I..." "You've trained your hands for a year." Master Tang's voice was calm. "Tonight you change only twice: red to black, black to gold. Remember: whatever happens on stage, however nervous you are, you must not stop." 23

Master Tang helped him get ready with one hand, talking all the while about the things to watch out for. Ming Hao put on Master's stage costume. It was far too big, so the owner found a few clips and pinned it for him. Although his hands would not stop trembling, he did his best to remember every word Master said. The gongs and drums sounded. Ming Hao took a deep breath and walked out onto the stage. 24

第一张脸

25 台下的灯光很亮，明浩[†]几乎看不清楚观众的脸，只听见自己的心跳。他像在公园里练了一千遍那样，走了几步，转身，甩[‡]头，扇子一挡——红脸变成了黑脸。台下有人大声叫了一声：“好！”

26 可是第二次，他的手拉了一下，面具[§]没有下来。明浩的脑子里一下子空了。台下有几个客人开始小声说话。就在这时候，他想起了师傅的话：不能停。他没有停，而是又在台上走了一圈，凭着一年练出来的感觉，自然地一转身，把扇子举了起来。这一次，金色的脸出现了。

27 最后，他把扇子一收，露出[¶]了自己的脸——一张满是汗的少年的脸。台下先是安静了一秒钟，然后响起了热烈的掌声[*]。

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† 明浩 *Míng Hào* Ming Hao (the boy)
‡ 甩 *shuǎi* to flick, to swing
§ 面具 *miànjù* mask
¶ 露出 *lùchū* to reveal
* 掌声 *zhǎngshēng* applause

The First Face

The lights were so bright that Ming Hao could hardly make out the faces of 25
the audience; all he could hear was his own heartbeat. Just as he had practised a thousand times in the park, he took a few steps, turned, flicked his head, swept the fan across, and the red face became a black one. Someone in the audience shouted, "Bravo!"

But the second time, he pulled and the mask did not come down. Ming 26
Hao's mind went blank. A few people in the audience began to whisper. Just then he remembered Master's words: don't stop. He didn't stop. Instead he walked another circle around the stage and, relying on the feel he had built up over a year, turned naturally and raised the fan. This time, the golden face appeared.

Finally he closed the fan and revealed his own face: a boy's face, covered in 27
sweat. For a second the audience was silent, and then warm applause broke out.

27 倒茶的王叔叔[1]放下长嘴壶[2]，第一个站了起来。那天晚上，茶馆[3]里没有一个人不为他鼓掌。

28 明浩[4]回到后台[5]，腿还在发软。他低着头说：“师傅，对不起，第二次我差点儿失败了。”唐师傅[6]没有批评他，只是问：“停了吗？”“没有。”“那就够了。”说完，师傅转过身去。明浩好像看见，他偷偷地笑了一下。

29 第二天，唐师傅让明浩带着爸爸妈妈来茶馆。他换了一件干净的衣服，坐在桌子旁边，桌上放着一杯茶。“按老规矩[7]，拜师[8]的时候，徒弟[9]要给师傅敬[10]一杯茶。”明浩这才明白过来，激动得说不出话来。他用双手拿起茶杯，恭恭敬敬[11]地送到了师傅面前。

1 王叔叔 *Wáng shūshu* Uncle Wang
2 长嘴壶 *chángzuǐhú* long-spouted teapot
3 茶馆 *cháguǎn* teahouse
4 明浩 *Míng Hào* Ming Hao (the boy)
5 后台 *hòutái* backstage
6 唐师傅 *Táng shīfu* Master Tang
7 规矩 *guīju* rule, custom
8 拜师 *bàishī* to formally become an apprentice
9 徒弟 *túdì* apprentice, disciple
10 敬 *jìng* to offer (tea) respectfully
11 恭恭敬敬 *gōnggōngjìngjìng* respectfully

Uncle Wang, the tea pourer, put down his long-spouted pot and was the first 27
to stand up. That night, there was not a single person in the teahouse who did not applaud him.

When Ming Hao got backstage, his legs were still shaking. He hung his 28
head. "Master, I'm sorry. I nearly failed the second change." Master Tang did not scold him. He only asked, "Did you stop?" "No." "Then that's enough." With that, Master turned away, and Ming Hao thought he saw him smile to himself.

The next day, Master Tang asked Ming Hao to come to the teahouse with 29
his parents. He had changed into clean clothes and sat beside a table with a cup of tea on it. "By the old custom, when an apprentice is formally taken on, he offers his master a cup of tea." Only then did Ming Hao understand, and he was too moved to speak. He lifted the cup with both hands and respectfully offered it to his master.

30 唐师傅[1]喝了茶，从木盒子里拿出一张旧的红色面具[2]，交给明浩[3]。“这是我的师傅给我的第一张脸。在川剧[4]里，红色代表忠诚[5]和勇敢。”他停了一下，又说：“你知道我为什么收你吗？不是因为你昨天演得好。那天那个拍视频的人来找你，我就站在楼梯后面。”明浩吃惊地看着师傅。

31 “手可以慢慢练，方法也可以慢慢教，可是一个人值不值得信任，是练不出来、也教不出来的。川剧是国家级非物质文化遗产[6]，可是遗产不是放在博物馆里的东西，要靠人一代一代传下去。变脸[7]能传到今天，靠的不只是手快，更是人心。我老了，这门手艺[8]不能不传下去。现在，我终于找到了可以传的人。”

32 那天晚上，明浩把红色的面具放在桌子上，看了很久。

1 唐师傅 *Táng shīfu* Master Tang
2 面具 *miànjù* mask
3 明浩 *Míng Hào* Ming Hao (the boy)
4 川剧 *Chuānjù* Sichuan opera
5 忠诚 *zhōngchéng* loyalty
6 非物质文化遗产 *fēiwùzhì wénhuà yíchǎn* intangible cultural heritage
7 变脸 *biànliǎn* face-changing (Sichuan opera art)
8 手艺 *shǒuyì* craft, skill

Master Tang drank the tea, took an old red mask out of the wooden box and handed it to Ming Hao. "This is the first face my master gave me. In Sichuan opera, red stands for loyalty and courage." He paused, then went on. "Do you know why I'm taking you on? It's not because you performed well yesterday. The day that video man came to find you, I was standing behind the stairs." Ming Hao stared at his master in astonishment. 30

"Hands can be trained slowly, and the method can be taught slowly, but whether a person can be trusted is something no training and no teaching can produce. Sichuan opera is national intangible cultural heritage, but heritage isn't something you put in a museum. It has to be passed on by people, generation after generation. If face-changing has survived until today, it's not only thanks to quick hands, but even more to people's hearts. I'm getting old, and this craft must be handed down. Now, at last, I've found someone I can hand it down to." 31

That night Ming Hao laid the red mask on his desk and looked at it for a long time. 32

32 他想起一年前那个站在茶馆[†]最后面的自己：那时候，他只想知道变脸[‡]的秘密。现在他才明白，师傅真正交给他的，不是一个秘密，而是一份信任。窗外，城市的灯慢慢地亮了起来。明浩[§]拿起扇子，又开始练习了。

† 茶馆 *cháguǎn* teahouse

‡ 变脸 *biànliǎn* face-changing (Sichuan opera art)

§ 明浩 *Míng Hào* Ming Hao (the boy)

He thought of himself a year ago, standing at the very back of the teahouse: back then, all he wanted was to learn the secret of face-changing. Only now did he understand that what Master had truly given him was not a secret, but his trust. Outside the window, the city lights were slowly coming on. Ming Hao picked up his fan and began to practise again.